Al Qaeda

Did Al Qaeda really exist? Many Pakistanis were confused about it after 2001. Most Pakistanis did not believe that Osama bin Laden ever existed and if he was a reality, he had been killed in 'Tora Bora' (Afghanistan) by the US Daisy Cutters in 2002.[10] These confusions and perceptions about the existence, strength, ideology and leadership of Al Qaeda were worldwide, even in the US (Byman, 2003).[11]

Despite this widespread ambiguity, most lower- and middle-class Pakistanis perceived Osama bin Laden as an 'imagined hero', whereas the educated upper middle class suspected that the CIA created him.[12] These myths, confusions and ambiguities were mainly due to lack of trust in the US, mistrust against the military rule of General Musharraf, Al Qaeda's elusive form and structure and partial coverage of events by Pakistani media.

Arrests and deportation of approximately 700 Al Qaeda terrorists by Pakistan slightly contributed to removing this misconception (*The Post*, 2005). In fact, the US bombing on Afghanistan and the consistent news of collateral damage kept the people fixated on viewing the US as an aggressor. Thus, bin Laden's popularity increased, which could be evidenced from one particular incident. At the end of December 2002, the funeral prayer of Aimal Kansi, who was put to death by the court orders for killing CIA officers outside the agency headquarters in Langley, in January 1993, was held at the Quetta stadium. It saw the fervour and anguish of thousands of participants, including army officers, police officers, civil bureaucrats, politicians and common people, which was so large that even the public meetings held by the political parties and General Musharraf could not attract such a crowd in their election campaigns at the same venue.[13]

In 2002, as a result of the US operation 'Anaconda' against Al Qaeda in Afghanistan, it was dispersed and forced to move towards the treacherous mountains of Hindu Kush along the Pak–Afghan border. Many of them sneaked into FATA. Since then it had been changing shelters from FATA to urban areas of KP, Punjab and Sindh and back to FATA to avoid annihilation by the US and the Pakistani security forces. It defied obliteration due to its mercurial form and structure. On intolerable pressure, it vanished from one area and appeared at the other.